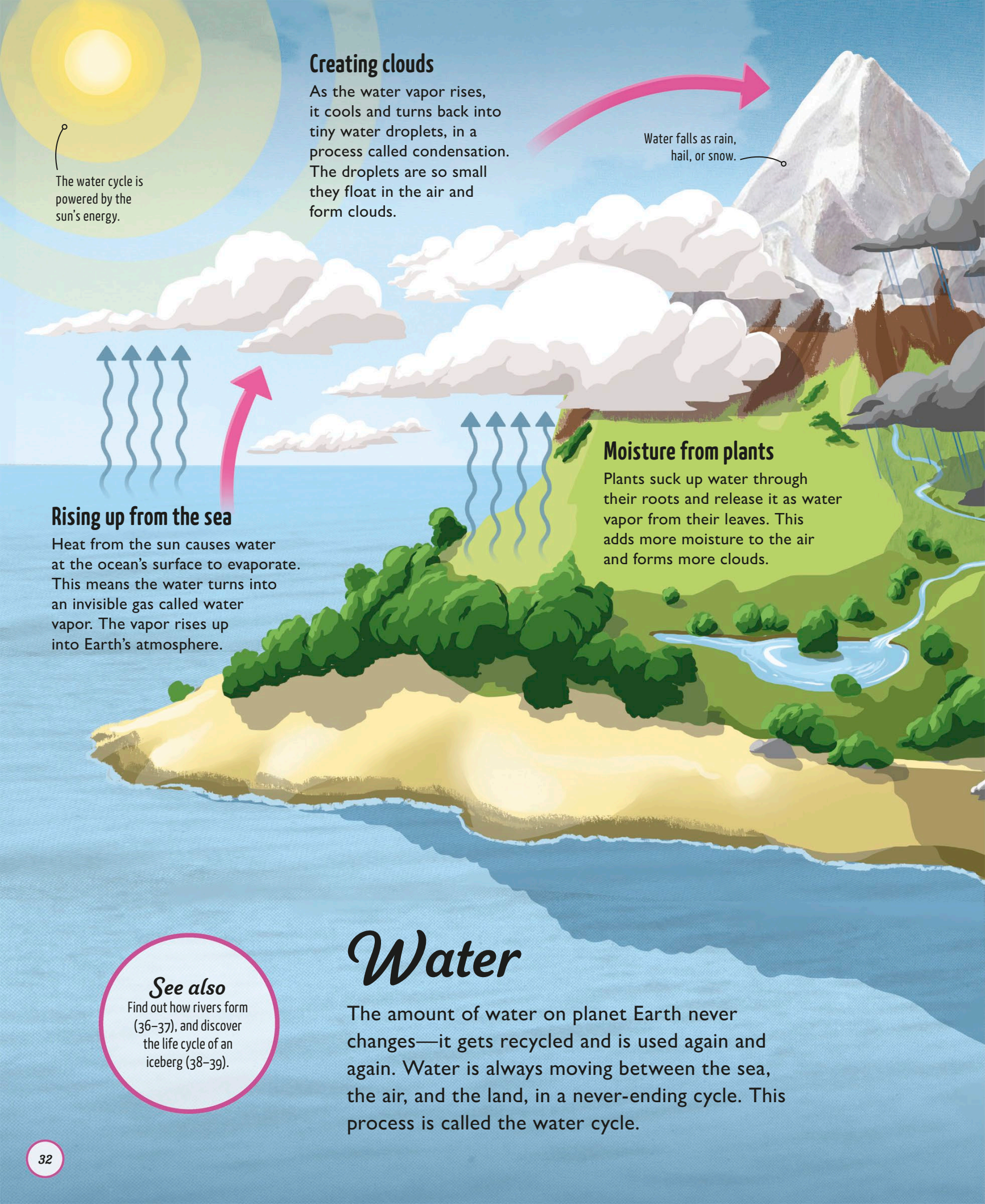




The water cycle is powered by the sun's energy.

Creating clouds

As the water vapor rises, it cools and turns back into tiny water droplets, in a process called condensation. The droplets are so small they float in the air and form clouds.

Water falls as rain, hail, or snow.

Rising up from the sea

Heat from the sun causes water at the ocean's surface to evaporate. This means the water turns into an invisible gas called water vapor. The vapor rises up into Earth's atmosphere.

Moisture from plants

Plants suck up water through their roots and release it as water vapor from their leaves. This adds more moisture to the air and forms more clouds.

See also

Find out how rivers form (36–37), and discover the life cycle of an iceberg (38–39).

Water

The amount of water on planet Earth never changes—it gets recycled and is used again and again. Water is always moving between the sea, the air, and the land, in a never-ending cycle. This process is called the water cycle.